were over, was their argument. ‘Why the hurry? Why mix issues before the assembly elections? Why take a risk at this stage?’ Advani asked BJP leaders who met him. He tossed up another googly by suggesting that Modi was not the only ‘successful’ BJP chief minister. ‘Look at Shivraj Singh Chauhan and Raman Singh. They, too, have been chief ministers for a decade—should their credentials as leaders be totally ignored?’ was the question he raised.

Chauhan was almost, in fact, being pushed by the Advani camp as a more acceptable alternative to Modi. In a speech in Gwalior, Advani suggested that Chauhan’s achievements in Madhya Pradesh were, to some extent, greater than Modi. ‘He has turned a backward, BIMARU state into a developed one, Modi has inherited a healthy state,’ he claimed. He even likened Chauhan’s understated style to Vajpayee’s.

Ever-smiling, self-effacing and courteous, the fifty-five-year-old Chauhan was a man with few enemies. If Modi had an aversion to an intrusive media, Chauhan went out of his way to cultivate journalists. Many journalists, including me, would often get invites to attend functions in Bhopal. ‘We’ll organize everything, *aap bas aa jaiye* [you just have to come],’ he would promise. I did not avail of any such junket, but those who did tell me that Chauhan was the perfect host.

But if Chauhan had any prime ministerial ambitions, he had carefully masked them. I asked him once about Advani equating him with Vajpayee. ‘*Main toh Advaniji ko bahut adar karta hoon par mein toh ek sadharan karyakarta hoon’* (I respect Advaniji a lot, but at the end of the day, I am a humble worker), he said with his characteristic humility. And then reminded me once again that I must visit him in Bhopal soon.

But any attempt to drag in Chauhan as a prime ministerial option was never going to gain any traction. The leadership of the BJP and the RSS had made up its mind and wasn’t going to concede an inch. The Modi decision was irreversible. ‘Frankly, some of us were just tired of Advaniji’s constant nitpicking. We even felt that if he wants to resign and leave the party, let him—we were done with his petulance,’ a senior BJP leader told me.